

Chicago Tribune



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WEDNESDAY, JUNE 4, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



White Sox fans, including Vincent Carter, center, and his son, Vance Carter, second from right, sit outside of Rate Field in Chicago before Tuesday night's game between the Sox and Detroit Tigers. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Pro sports nexus in city? The 78 has the potential

Don't count out a new White Sox stadium being built next to the Fire's at the South Loop site

By Robert Channick
Chicago Tribune

There may be a few more balls in the air at The 78 than just the Chicago Fire's proposed \$650 million soccer stadium.

In the wake of Tuesday's announcement that the Fire's privately financed, 22,000-seat stadium could open for play before the 2028 MLS season, the White Sox said they are still considering building their proposed new ballpark at the South Loop site as well, potentially creating a new pro sports nexus in Chicago.

At least one industry analyst said shoehorning two new

IN CHICAGO SPORTS: Did the Fire just call dibs on The 78? Or are the White Sox's ballpark dreams still alive?

stadiums in the mostly vacant 62-acre site is not only viable, but potentially a boon for both teams and the city, as well as Related Midwest's long-dormant megadevelopment.

"It could work," said Marc Ganis, a Chicago-based sports marketing consultant. "They would have to work out the use of the infrastructure and the parking and scheduling and things of that nature. I think it'd be great for the city."

The Fire plan to build the open-air soccer stadium at the north end of the former rail yard along the Chicago River at Roosevelt Road. The stadium, designed by architectural firm Gensler, would feature a natural grass pitch, an array of seating — including club options and luxury suites — and an intimate setting for Fire fans to cheer on the team.

As part of the proposed development, the Fire is buying 9 acres of land at The 78, the team and developer confirmed. That leaves plenty of room for the White Sox to build an adjacent ballpark, Ganis said.

Last year, the White Sox proposed a new publicly funded

ballpark at The 78, but Springfield lawmakers balked at the idea of contributing a reported \$1 billion to build it. The team, though, has not given up on moving in, according to a statement issued Tuesday.

"Related Midwest first approached the White Sox about building a new ballpark on a piece of property they were developing, and we continue to consider the site as an option," the White Sox said. "We believe in Related Midwest's vision for The 78 and remain confident the riverfront location could serve as a home to both teams. We continue to have

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3rd fatal shooting near Gaza aid site

Palestinian officials say at least 27 dead; Israel disputes toll

By Mohammad Jahjough, Sammy Magdy and Fatma Khaled
Associated Press

RAFAH, Gaza Strip — Israeli forces fired on people as they headed toward an aid distribution site in Gaza on Tuesday, killing at least 27, Palestinian health officials and witnesses said, in the third such shooting in three days. The army said it fired "near a few individual suspects" who left the designated route, approached its forces and ignored warning shots.

The near-daily shootings have occurred after an Israeli and U.S.-backed foundation established aid distribution points inside Israeli military zones, a system it says is designed to circumvent Hamas. The United Nations has rejected the new system, saying it doesn't address Gaza's mounting hunger crisis and allows Israel to use aid as a weapon.

The Israeli military said it "fired to drive away suspects."

In a statement, army spokesperson Effie Defrin said "the numbers of casualties published by Hamas were exaggerated" but that the incident was being investigated. He said the army is not preventing Palestinians in Gaza from reaching aid in the distribution areas, but rather allowing it.

The Gaza Humanitarian Foundation, which operates the sites, says there has been no violence in or around them. On Tuesday, it acknowledged that the Israeli military was investigating whether civilians were wounded "after moving beyond the designated safe corridor and into a closed military zone," in an area that was "well beyond our secure distribution site."

A spokesperson for the group

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Johnson wants aldermen to implement grocery tax

Finance leaders say failure to do so would add to city's budget gap

By Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson is pushing aldermen to add a city grocery tax in Chicago as the long-established state grocery levy expires.

Johnson's top finance leaders urged aldermen to implement the tax soon during a Tuesday meeting of the City Council's Revenue Subcommittee. Failing to install the tax would blow an additional \$80 million hole in Chicago's 2026 budget as the city already faces a budget gap of around \$1 billion, Budget Director Annette Guzman said.

"We must reaffirm the grocery tax before the state's deadline," Guzman told the nine aldermen on hand for the hearing.

Gov. JB Pritzker argued the 1% grocery sales tax is regressive and hits poor families harder when he announced last year he would end it, though the same state budget that removed the grocery levy added almost \$900 million in tax hikes. But Pritzker left the door open for local governments — which receive all of the tax's revenue — to implement the same tax on their own.

Over 150 communities across Illinois have decided to enact local grocery taxes, leaving many Illinoisans set to pay the same bill to a different body. Johnson and the City Council have so far put

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A black-crowned night heron preens itself atop a nest under construction at Lincoln Park Zoo on May 6. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

AN UNLIKELY RELATIONSHIP

Endangered herons seek out Lincoln Park Zoo's red wolves for protection

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

Small and stocky birds perch, hunched over, on the tree-tops and branches of Lake Okeechobee on the edge of Florida's swampy Everglades for the better part of winter. The alligators swarming the murky waters below don't faze the black-crowned night herons — in fact, the birds count on them for protection. And when some fly away for the summer, they seek out other animals that can

do the same.

This heron is the world's most widely distributed species of its kind, found on every continent except for Australia and Antarctica. But it's been endangered in Illinois since the 1970s as the population has declined across the Great Lakes region because of human harassment and disappearing wetlands.

For the last 15 years, however, Chicago has become a popular summer hub and the location of the last remaining breeding colony of the species in the

state, specifically atop the red wolf enclosure at the Lincoln Park Zoo. Hundreds of black-crowned night herons flock there starting in mid-March every year, migrating from nearby Indiana and Kentucky, and from farther away like Louisiana, Florida and Georgia, and more recently, even Cuba.

"(It's) a story that most people find a little bit ironic, that they settle above this particular predatory species. But seems that

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The mac and cheese with crawfish at Nafsi. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

INSIDE

Chef sets restaurant's standard of excellence

Nafsi brings a chef's heart and soul food to the South Shore Cultural Center in Chicago. **Food & Health**

State lawmakers again fail to act on hemp

A study notes lack of regulation means no oversight of ingredients, potency or marketing. **Business**

